

Baptism Faith Precedes

doc-baptism-faith-precedes

Sacraments · Baptism · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

breadth broad
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

In the New Testament pattern, conscious faith precedes baptism.

In plain language

Look at how the Greek verbs line up in the conversion stories, confirmed word by word in the morphology (the grammatical word forms). In Acts 2:41 the people who first received the word, named by the 'having received' participle (apodexamenoi, a completed-action participle), are the very ones the verb says were baptized. In Acts 8:12 the wording is 'and when they believed' (hote de episteusan), and only then were they being baptized, and the people are named as men and women. Acts 18:8 stacks three verbs in order for the many Corinthians, hearing, then believing, then being baptized. Mark 16:16 names believing before baptism in the phrase 'the one having believed and having been baptized', and it ties condemnation to unbelief alone, not to a lack of baptism. Acts 2:38 opens with the command 'Repent!' (Metanoesate) before the command to be baptized. So in these reported cases the language consistently places a conscious response ahead of the act of baptism, which is why the proposition lands as affirmed. The harder texts are the household baptisms. Acts 16:15 baptizes Lydia and her house, Acts 16:33 baptizes the jailer and all his, and 1 Corinthians 1:16 baptizes the house of Stephanas. In each the Greek records the baptism of a household (oikos), without spelling out the faith of every single member. The text does state the faith of the head of the house, and in the jailer's case it says he rejoiced and 'had believed in God' (pepisteukos, a perfect-tense form meaning a completed action whose result still stands), but that believing word is singular and agrees with the jailer, and the one word that might stretch the believing to the whole house, 'as a whole household' (panoikei), occurs only once in the whole New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its reach cannot be checked against any other verse. That single open word, plus the plain silence about each member, is the lexical (word-level) reason careful readers divide. The verbs give a clear order for the named adult converts but do not by themselves prove or disprove that everyone in those households believed before being baptized.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0191	ἀκούω	akouo	to hear	452
G0569	ἄπιστέω	apisteo	to disbelieve	8
G0588	ἀποδέχομαι	apodechomai	to receive	7
G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	82
G2632	κατακρίνω	katakrinō	to condemn	
G3340	μετανοέω	metanoeo	to repent	36
G3614	οἰκία	oikia	home	

G3624	οἶκος	oikos	house	114
G3753	ὅτε	hote	when	124
G3832	πανοικεί	panoikei	with all the house	1
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	251
G4982	σώζω	sōzō	to save	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

In every cited conversion account the verbs of receiving, hearing, repenting, or believing stand grammatically and temporally before the verbs of baptizing. Acts 2:41 makes the having-received participle (apodexamenoi, a completed past action in participle form meaning 'having welcomed') the subject of the were-baptized verb (ebaptisthesan, a completed past passive action). Acts 8:12 reads 'when they believed' (hote de episteusan) and then the ongoing past 'they were being baptized' (the imperfect ebaptizonto, meaning ongoing or repeated past action). Acts 18:8 chains hearing (akouontes) then the ongoing past 'they were believing' (the imperfect episteuon) then 'they were being baptized' (ebaptizonto). Mark 16:16 orders 'having believed' (pisteusas) before 'having been baptized' (baptistheis) and pairs condemnation only with unbelief. Acts 2:38 puts the command 'Repent!' (Metanoesate) before the command 'let him be baptized' (baptistheto). So the recorded sequence consistently places a conscious response ahead of baptism, which supports the proposition. Confidence stays medium, not high, because the pattern rests on one author across mostly one book, because it is narrated description rather than stated rule, and because the household baptisms (Acts 16:15, Acts 16:33, 1 Corinthians 1:16) report the baptizing of a household (oikos) without itemizing each member's faith, with the one collective word 'as a whole household' (panoikei) in Acts 16:34 being a single-occurrence term (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose scope the text does not fix.

Scripture

Acts.2.41 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0588 ἀποδέχομαι, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. The word forms confirm the order directly. The 'having received' or 'having welcomed' participle (apodexamenoi, G0588, a completed past action in participle form, labeled V-ADP-NPM, meaning aorist deponent participle nominative plural masculine), describing those who welcomed his word, is the grammatical subject (the doer) of the main verb 'they were baptized' (ebaptisthesan, G0907, V-API-3P, a completed past passive verb in the third person plural). The participle describes a completed reception of the proclaimed word that is logically and temporally prior to the act of baptism, so the ones baptized are exactly the ones who first received the message. The same subjects are then said to be added (prosetethesan, 'they were added') and numbered about three thousand souls. Reception of the apostolic word stands grammatically prior to the baptismal act.

Acts.8.12 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3753 ὅτε, G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. The time-marking conjunction 'when' (hote, G3753) governs the completed past verb 'they believed' (episteusan, G4100, V-AAI-3P, a completed past action in the third person plural), and the ongoing past verb 'they were being baptized' (ebaptizonto, G0907, V-IPi-3P, an imperfect tense or ongoing or repeated past action in passive voice and third person plural) follows. The construction 'and when they believed ... they were being baptized' (hote de episteusan ... ebaptizonto) sets believing the proclamation about the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ as the prior condition, with the ongoing baptizing following upon that belief. The named subjects are 'men and also women' (andres te kai gunaikes, G0435 for 'men' and G1135 for 'women', both nominative plural meaning the grammatical subject form, plural), persons capable of the conscious act the verb 'believe' (pisteuo) describes.

Acts.18.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0191 ἀκούω, G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. The clause 'many of the Corinthians, hearing, were believing and were being baptized' (polloi ton Korinthon akouontes episteuon kai ebaptizonto) chains a 'hearing' participle in ongoing simple form (akouontes, G0191, V-PAP-NPM, a present active participle, nominative plural masculine, that is, an ongoing-action participle as grammatical subject) to the ongoing past verbs 'they were believing' (episteuon, G4100, V-IAI-3P, an imperfect or ongoing or repeated past action in third person plural) and 'they were being baptized' (ebaptizonto, G0907, V-IPi-3P, an imperfect passive in third person plural). The verb order places hearing, then believing, then baptizing, with the same subjects carried through all three. In the same verse Crispus the synagogue ruler is said to 'have believed' (episteusen, G4100, V-AAI-3S, a completed past action in third person singular) the Lord with his whole household ('with his whole house', sun holo to oiko autou, from oikos G3624, household), so the household notice itself is attached to a stated act of belief by the head of the house, though the faith of each member is not separately itemized.

Mark.16.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G0569 ἀπιστέω

Force. The substantival completed-past participles 'the one having believed and having been baptized' (ho pisteusas kai baptistheis, from G4100, V-AAP-NSM, an aorist active participle nominative singular masculine, that is, a completed-action participle used as a noun, and G0907, V-APP-NSM, an aorist passive participle, nominative singular masculine) place believing first and baptism second in the coordinated pair before the future 'will be saved' (sothesetai). The contrasting clause 'but the one having disbelieved will be condemned' (ho de apistesas katakrithesetai, from apisteo G0569, to disbelieve) pairs only with unbelief, never with non-baptism, an imbalance that highlights faith as the operative condition. This verse stands within the longer ending of Mark, which in the lexical store is carried only under the K and O edition markers (the Byzantine and majority-text manuscript witnesses) and is absent from the earliest critical text (the textual edition built from the oldest manuscript witnesses), so its evidential weight is qualified.

Acts.2.38 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετανοέω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G0859 ἄφεσις

Force. The completed-action command 'Repent!' (Metanoesate, G3340, V-AAM-2P, an aorist active imperative in second person plural, that is, a direct command for a completed action by 'you all') precedes the completed-action passive command 'let each of you be baptized' (baptistheto hekastos hymon, G0907, V-APM-3S, an aorist passive imperative in third person singular). So the called-for repentance heads the order of commands before baptism. Repentance is a conscious turning that stands first. The verse functions partly as a complicating piece of data, because the preposition-plus-noun phrase 'for the forgiveness of sins' (eis aphesin ton hamarton, using eis G1519 plus the direct-object form, and aphesis G0859 meaning release or forgiveness) can be read as making baptism the means of forgiveness rather than the seal of prior faith. The 'for' phrase (eis) is grammatically open between a purpose or result sense and a cause or reference sense, and the words alone do not settle it, so this verse is marked neutral.

Acts.16.34 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3832 πανοικεί, G4100 πιστεύω

Force. The jailer 'rejoiced' (egalliasato, G0021, V-ADI-3S, a completed past deponent verb in third person singular) 'as a whole household' (panoikei, G3832), 'having believed in God' (pepisteukos to theo, from G4100, V-RAP-NSM, a perfect active participle, nominative singular masculine, meaning a completed action whose result still stands, in participle form as grammatical subject). The participle 'having believed' (pepisteukos) is in the perfect tense (a completed action whose result still stands), masculine and singular, so it agrees grammatically with the jailer alone, not with a plural household subject. The adverb 'as a whole household' (panoikei) sits between the rejoicing verb and the believing participle, and its reach is genuinely open, it can attach to the rejoicing (the whole house rejoiced) or extend the believing to the whole house. 'As a whole household' (panoikei) occurs exactly once in the New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its precise sense and scope cannot be triangulated against any other usage. This verse is therefore the lexical pivot of the contested case.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.2.41	Acts.2.47	openbible	8
Acts.8.12	Acts.2.38	openbible	11
Acts.18.8	Rom.10.14	openbible	5
Mark.16.16	John.3.36	openbible	194
Acts.2.38	Acts.22.16	openbible	88
Acts.16.31	John.1.12	openbible	39
Acts.16.15	Acts.11.14	openbible	11
Acts.16.33	Acts.16.15	openbible	6
Acts.16.33	1Cor.1.16	openbible	7
Acts.2.38	Acts.2.16	tsk	1
Acts.18.8	Acts.10.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.16.15 · addressed

Lydia is baptized together with her household ('she was baptized and her house', ebaptisthe kai ho oikos autes, where oikos G3624 means household). The preceding verse 14 reports that she 'was hearing' (ekouen, G0191, in the imperfect tense, that is, ongoing or repeated past action) and that the Lord 'opened her heart' (dienoixen ten kardian) to attend to what Paul said, and verse 15 has her call herself 'faithful to the Lord' (pisten to kurio, using the adjective for 'believing' or 'faithful', G4103). So her own attentive faith is stated, but the faith of each household member is not. The verbs fix the sequence for Lydia herself and are silent about the rest, so the text is compatible with faith preceding baptism for her while neither asserting nor denying prior faith for every member of the household (oikos). The silence complicates a strict universal rule without overturning the verbal order seen for the named converts.

Acts.16.33 · addressed

The jailer and 'all who were his' (autos kai hoi autou pantes, where pantes G3956 means 'all') are baptized at once after verse 32 says the word of the Lord was spoken to 'all those in his house' (pasin tois en te oikia autou, where oikia G3614 means house or household), which puts hearing before baptizing for the household. Verse 34 then says he rejoiced 'as a whole household' (panoikei, G3832), 'having believed' (pepisteukos, G4100, a perfect active participle, that is, a completed action whose result still stands, in masculine singular). The believing participle is grammatically singular and agrees with the jailer, while 'as a whole household' (panoikei) is an adverb occurring only this once in the New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose scope between the rejoicing and the believing the grammar does not fix. So the case is consistent with faith preceding baptism for those who heard, but it leaves the faith status of any non-speaking members unsettled on lexical grounds alone, and that one once-only adverb is the precise point the words do not resolve.

1Cor.1.16 · addressed

Paul says he baptized 'the household of Stephanas' (ton Stephanos oikon, using oikos G3624, household) with no statement of who believed and in what order. The notice is purely backward-looking and incidental, prompted by his point that he baptized few. 1 Corinthians 16:15 later describes the same household (oikian, G3614, house or household) as the firstfruits of Achaia who devoted themselves to ministry, which implies conscious commitment by that household, but the baptism notice itself carries no verbal marker of prior faith for each member. The 'household' (oikos) formula here is silent on sequence, so it neither supports nor contradicts the proposition and stands as an unresolved silence rather than a counter-pattern.

Col.2.12 · addressed

Colossians 2:11 to 12 sets a 'circumcision' and 'baptism' parallel (peritome, G4061, circumcision, and baptismo, G0909, baptism), which can be read as aligning baptism with a covenant sign given apart from the recipient's prior conscious faith. But verse 12 itself states that the burial and rising with Christ in baptism is 'through faith' (dia tes pisteos, using pistis G4102, faith or trust), naming faith as the operative means even within the covenant sign language. The lexical data thus supplies the covenant parallel and a faith clause in the same breath, so the words neither establish a sign administered without faith nor exclude one, and the construction is the kind of two readings the vocabulary does not rank. It is addressed and left honestly open.

Concordance traversed

G0907, G4100, G0588, G0191, G3340, G3753, G0569, G2632, G0859, G3624, G3832, G3614, G4982

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

mark-longer-ending at Mark.16.16: impact minor. Mark 16:16 belongs to the longer ending (Mark 16:9 to 20). In the lexical store its tokens carry only the K and O edition markers (the Byzantine and majority-text manuscript witnesses) and the passage is absent from the earliest Alexandrian witnesses (the oldest, Egyptian-tradition manuscript line). Removing it weakens one anchor, but the Acts narratives carry the believe-then-baptize verbal sequence independently, so the impact on the verdict is minor rather than material.

Inputs report 'not_in_ecm_scope' as true and an empty variant_units list (the ECM apparatus is the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, and 'not in ECM scope' means this passage falls outside the portion currently digitized), and a direct query found zero VariantUnit nodes for Mark 16, since the ingested ECM window is 3 John only. The Mark longer-ending question is a big-picture text-critical matter handled outside CBGM micro-variant tooling (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a computer-assisted technique for tracing manuscript relationships at the level of individual word variants), so 'ecm_status' is recorded as 'n/a' (not applicable) for this run.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. credobaptism, paedobaptism, covenant_theology

credobaptism: affirmed · Reads the verb order in Acts 2:41, Acts 8:12, Acts 18:8, Mark 16:16, and Acts 2:38 as a consistent and therefore normative (rule-setting) pattern in which receiving the word, hearing, repenting, or believing always precedes baptism. On this reading the household texts are instances where the believing members were the ones baptized, and Acts 16:34 with its perfect singular 'having believed' (pepisteukos, the perfect tense form, a completed action whose result still stands) and the word spoken to all in the house in Acts 16:32 shows the household hearing and believing before being baptized.

paedobaptism: disputed · Reads the 'household' (oikos) formula in Acts 16:15, Acts 16:33, and 1 Corinthians 1:16 as household-inclusive baptism that does not require each member's prior personal faith, treating the believer baptism narratives as descriptions of adult converts rather than a rule excluding members who cannot yet believe. It notes that the conversion accounts never state a universal exclusion, that the household texts itemize no individual faith, that 'as a whole household' (panoikei) in Acts 16:34 is a single-occurrence word (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose scope is open, and that Colossians 2:11 to 12 links baptism to the covenant sign of circumcision.

covenant_theology: disputed · Reads Colossians 2:11 to 12 as making baptism the new covenant counterpart to circumcision, a sign that under the prior covenant was applied to the household including infants, and treats the household baptisms as continuity of that household principle. The same passage names faith ('through faith', dia tes pisteos) as the operative means, so the vocabulary supplies both the covenant sign parallel and the faith clause without ranking them, leaving the scope question open at the level of the words.

The lexical (word-level) data settles the verbal order for the named adult converts but cannot by itself decide whether the household (oikos) baptisms included members who had not personally believed. That is the exact point where the frameworks diverge, and the words supply a clear pattern for the persons they describe without supplying a stated universal rule about household members who cannot yet believe.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether, in the conversion accounts of the New Testament, the verbs of believing, receiving the word, or repenting stand prior to the verbs of baptizing, and whether any baptisms are recorded without prior personal faith for every person baptized.

The phrase 'the New Testament pattern' presupposes that the narratives establish a single rule-setting norm, which is itself part of what is contested. The verdict was derived on the original stem by testing the verbal sequence directly in the word forms, confirming that receiving, hearing, repenting, or believing precedes baptizing in every named conversion, then noting that the household (oikos) texts narrate baptism of a household without itemizing each member's faith and that the one collective term 'as a whole household' (panoikei) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) of open scope.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.41
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.8.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.18.8
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.16.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.38
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.34
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0907
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4100
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3832

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.16.33
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.2.38

License audit

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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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